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Abstract

Well-being is historically conceptualized in vague terms related to psychosocial variables and researched through the absence of poor health outcomes, including anxiety, depression, suicide risk, and poor overall mental health. However, recently, there has been a shift in the literature so that wellness scholarship includes basic rights and access to factors associated with mental health. The World Health Organization (2011) considers mental health synonymous with a state of "wellbeing, in which every individual realizes his or her own potential, can cope with the normal stresses of life, can work productively and fruitfully, and is able to make a contribution to her or his community." While this definition begins to hint at the historical, political, economic, and other sociocultural systems that profoundly affect a person's wellness, it continues to neglect the co-constitutive elements of a person in context. A co-constitutive understanding acknowledges and emphasizes a *relational* dynamic that includes the productive interactions between people, culture, and the various social and physical places and spaces they at once shape and inhabit. This predominant and limited understanding is particularly pronounced when considering young people's well-being. Developmental theories are frequently conceptualized in sequential,

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linear, decontextualized ways. Moreover, developmental processes are often understood as static, predetermined, and staged accomplishments that are linked in a de facto way to future prospects. Through this developmental perspective, young people are often understood *non-relationally* or through a series of dichotomies separating, for example, individual from society and person from place; youths are often characterized as passive non-agents: as dependent recipients or receptors of culture, history, and education or as victims of poverty, racism, class, etc. This dominant developmental perspective obscures young people's active roles in their life endeavors, their abilities to impact the very contexts that shape them, and their potential to reimagine their possible futures. This blind spot not only limits our understanding of the dynamic systems involved in youth well-being but hides from view the powerful impact young people are making in their own worlds as they at once create and are created by the places they live in and through. In this chapter, we reconsider youth well-being as a fluid, dynamic, and relational process that is constituted by and through historical, political, economic, physical, and social geographies. The chapter illustrates this process through examples from the lives of indigenous young people in New York City, NY, rural subarctic Canada, and a remote village in Alaska, USA.

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Reconsidering Youth Well-Being as Fluid and Relational: A Dynamic Process at the Intersection of Their Physical and Social Geographies

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Abstract

Well-being is historically conceptualized in vague terms related to psychosocial variables and researched through the absence of poor health outcomes, including anxiety, depression, suicide risk, and poor overall mental health. However, recently, there has been a shift in the literature so that wellness scholarship includes basic rights and access to factors associated with mental health. The World Health Organization (2011) considers mental health synonymous with a state of "wellbeing, in which every individual realizes his or her own potential, can cope with the normal stresses of life, can work productively and fruitfully, and is able to make a contribution to her or his community." While this definition begins to hint at the historical, political, economic, and other sociocultural systems that profoundly affect a person's wellness, it continues to neglect the co-constitutive elements of a person in context. A co-constitutive understanding acknowledges and emphasizes a *relational* dynamic that includes the productive interactions between people, culture, and the various social and physical places and spaces they at once shape and inhabit. This predominant and limited understanding is particularly pronounced when considering young people's well-being. Developmental theories are frequently conceptualized in sequential, linear, decontextualized ways. Moreover, developmental processes are often understood as static, predetermined, and staged accomplishments that are linked in a de facto way to future prospects. Through this developmental perspective, young people are often understood *non-relationally* or through a series of dichotomies separating, for example, individual from society and person from place; youths are often characterized as passive non-agents: as dependent recipients or receptors of culture, history, and education or as victims of poverty, racism, class, etc. This dominant developmental perspective obscures young people's active roles in their life endeavors, their abilities to impact the very contexts that shape them, and their potential to reimagine their possible futures. This blind spot not only limits our understanding of the dynamic systems involved in youth well-being but hides from view the powerful impact young people are making in their own worlds as they at once create and are created by the places they live in and through. In this chapter, we reconsider youth well-being as a fluid, dynamic, and relational process that is constituted by and through historical, political, economic, physical, and social geographies. The chapter illustrates this process through examples from the lives of indigenous young people in New York City, NY, rural subarctic Canada, and a remote village in Alaska, USA.

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Introduction

Youth well-being is a relatively new field. For youth, much of the well-being literature relates to psychosocial variables such as a young person's ability to *develop* "psychologically, emotionally, socially, intellectually; and spiritually" (Edwards 2003). In this literature, young people are not quite "finished humans" and are therefore subject to developmental scrutiny and targeted interventions to ensure "proper growth." This perspective can be classified as positive youth development. This research trend is underpinned by developmental systems theory and considers human development to be a process that is shaped by a person's developmental assets (Lerner et al. 2005). The positive youth development literature "stress[es] the relative plasticity of human development and argue [s] that this potential for systematic change in behavior exists as a consequence of mutually influential relationships between the developing person and his or her biology, psychological characteristics, family, community, culture, physical and designed ecology, and historical niche" (p. 11). This perspective is useful, yet it often emphasizes individual-level understandings rather than contextual ones. Context shapes individual experience and opportunities but in ways that are sometimes difficult to discern. This chapter considers the intersection between individual-level factors, experiences, and opportunities and the social, political, economic, and physical contexts that give them shape. Our driving argument is that context matters greatly for youth well-being as young people both form and shape the contexts they inhabit.

It is well known (and unsurprising) that young people tend to enjoy better health when they have clear and positive ideas about who they are, how they fit into a larger group or contribute to a shared purpose, and have accessible and meaningful ways to do so (Armstrong et al. 2005; Barber 2013; Erikson 1968; Ungar 2004; Ungar 2011). If, as developmental theory posits, adolescence is a developmental period focused on identity exploration, commitment, or diffusion (Erikson 1968), it is a critical life stage that can establish a trajectory for a person's future. Young people who have key developmental assets, such as opportunities to engage in meaningful activities and gain competence, safe spaces to craft their sense of identity, and connect with adults, are better able Q2 to transition into healthy adulthood (Benson 2002; Benson et al. 2006; Eccles and Grootman 2002). For marginalized and economically struggling communities, these optimal developmental pathways for young people are more difficult to access.

The clear linkages between economic and social marginalization and youth health have gradually gained acceptance as "social determinants of health" in the public health literature (e.g., Levin and Browner 2005; Schulz and Northridge 2004). Recently, wellness scholarship includes basic rights and access to factors associated with mental health. The World Health Organization (2011) considers mental health synonymous with a state of "wellbeing, in which every individual realizes his or her own potential, can cope with the normal stresses of life, can work productively and fruitfully, and is able to make a contribution to her or his community." While this definition begins to place significance on the historical, political, economic, and social systems – and each individual's particular positioning within them – that profoundly affect a person's wellness, it theoretically neglects the co-constitutive elements of a person in context. A co-constitutive understanding acknowledges and emphasizes a relational dynamic that includes the interactions between persons, culture, and the various social and physical places and spaces they both shape and inhabit.

In research related to young people's well-being, it appears that this co-constitutive understanding is neglected. While there are many reasons for this neglect, a central reason is that theories underpinning much youth research conceptualize development in sequential, linear, decontextualized ways. There are two basic trends in the youth well-being literature. The first focuses on the social indicators of well-being, where the "emphasis is on the development of statistics that

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reflect important 'social conditions' and the monitoring of trends in a range of 'areas of social concern' over time" (Land et al. 2006, p.108). The second trend focuses on subjective well-being and often seeks to measure people's satisfaction with their life circumstances and their level of happiness or positive affect (Land et al. 2006). In this perspective, well-being is often conflated with "health-related quality of life" and measured by considering the physical health and aspects of psychological well-being, social relationships, role function, and environmental context of individuals (Smailes 2004).

Additionally, developmental processes are often understood as static, predetermined, and staged accomplishments linked to future prospects. Through this commonly employed developmental perspective, young people are often understood in a static way that cannot account for the fluid and interactional elements of lived youth well-being. When youth well-being is characterized *non-relationally*, it is often defined through a series of dichotomies separating, for example, individual from society and person from place; youth are often characterized as passive non-agents: as dependent recipients or receptors of culture, history, and education or as victims of poverty, racism, class, etc. Consequently, this dominant perspective obscures young people's active roles in their life endeavors, their abilities to impact the very contexts that shape them, and their potential to reimagine their possible futures. We argue that this blind spot not only limits our understanding of the dynamic systems involved in youth well-being but hides from view the powerful impact young people are making in their own worlds as they at once create and are created by the places they live in and through.

In an effort to rethink youth well-being as a fluid, relational process – a co-constitutive process which includes youth creating and being transformed by the sociocultural and physical worlds they inhabit – this chapter posits an inclusive theoretical framework that demonstrates how young people are continuously shaping and shaped by their worlds. The main argument is that this theoretical framework could offer a way forward for a more inclusive understanding of well-being: one that considers the importance of context and that reflects youth well-being as a fluid, dynamic, and relational process.

A Relational Theoretical Framework for Youth Well-Being

While several approaches are used to conceptualize youth development and engagement with their worlds, here the focus remains on two distinct perspectives: non-relational and relational. Non-relational means that young people, culture (including language, scripts, artifacts, and the like), and contexts they inhabit are understood as largely unrelated entities. These non-relational approaches are often dualistic: the theories (e.g., developmental theories) underpinning and guiding understanding often rest on a series of conceptual dichotomies separating culture from mind, mind from body, individual from society, and so forth. Translated into empirical inquiry, there is a focus on seeking universals in human behavior; culture is usually equated with a homogenized ethnic group (a "type" of people), and contextual elements are considered "independent variables" external to people (Rogoff and Angelillo 2002, pp. 211–216). More explicitly, people, place, and culture are conceptualized as essential isolated entities rather than as interrelated and inextricably linked.

A relational perspective, on the other hand, disputes this decontextualized, ahistorical understanding of youth engagement with their worlds and seeks to better understand the relationship among young people, culture, and contexts. While various theories might underpin relational approaches, we suggest an approach grounded primarily by the growing interdisciplinary field of sociocultural research (see Lewis et al. 2007) and by concepts from human geography can offer

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a relational, non-dualistic understanding of youth development. These perspectives can help explain the relationship between culture, people, and place (or context) and provide a co-constitutive understanding of young people's engagement with the world as a mutually transformative socio-cultural activity stimulated, enabled, and constrained by local places.

A broad array of disciplinary perspectives is necessary for a relational understanding of well-being, and one particularly helpful viewpoint comes from sociocultural theory. Sociocultural theory supports an understanding of people's development that includes the social and physical landscapes and the mutual transformative processes that make up these spaces. Significantly, sociocultural theory helps shift the focus away from youth, or place, or culture (or "artifacts" in sociocultural theory) and inspires us to think about these components as wholly linked and mutually productive. A significant and useful concept from sociocultural theory is "artifact mediation" or the "theory of mediation" which holds that people's actions and interactions with/in the world and with each other are mediated by cultural tools or artifacts (e.g., see Cole 1996; Vygotsky 1978; Wertsch 1995). Artifacts include the popular culture young people engage with daily: technology, sentient beings such as other people (parents, teachers, friends), as well as language, scripts, rituals, ways of acting, recipes, narratives, signs, beliefs, and the like (e.g., see Bruner 1990; Cole 1996). Artifacts (we could just say "culture") transform people and the environment with/in which they are produced and used (Cole and Engestrom 1993, p. 9). In fact, culture is the means by which the sociocultural world and young people (indeed all people) are connected, (re)produced, and transformed (ibid., p. 10).

Cultural artifacts are layered and multiple and mediate all of our actions and practices, as well as constrain and afford particular actions. What is more, cultural mediation does not happen in a vacuum. In fact, cultural mediation only exists in relation to and within particular contexts including, for instance, the physical place, social institutions, communities, and large discursive formations. For example, on a basic-level writing, this chapter is mediated by computers, by language, by models of chapters we have read before, and by our own values and standards which themselves are artifacts we have "internalized" from various sources including academic institutions as well as family and community. Moreover, our actions (and the artifacts mediating them) do not take place outside of particular contexts such as the "academia." What we do in the academy is informed and shaped by what we have done before and expect to do in the future. These actions are guided by the contexts (places, situations, and people) that make certain ways of behaving understandable, practical, valued, and necessary.

Perspectives from human geography help us to understand the complex contexts young people live within and through. Massey (1993, 1998; also Jess and Massey 1995) describes the relationship between place and space and argues that space consists of fluid social, cultural, political, and economic relations. Place is intertwined with space and, for this framework, is conceptualized as the material space (i.e., physical space) as well as the "meeting place" of social relations, global flows, and movements (i.e., sociocultural space) (Massey 1993, pp. 65–66). Places are always in process. They are dynamic, productive, and, as Massey (1993, p. 68) underlines, *particular*. That is, places are a unique intersection of relations and political, cultural, and social discourses making up the places themselves. Sections of New York City (NYC), for example, are unique and continuously changing not only because of the physical landscape (for instance, some areas include skyscrapers and other areas low-rise housing and small ethnic grocery stores) but because of the particular people, relationships, rules, and regulations making up the place. For example, people's arrivals and departures into places, their histories, the activities they enjoy, the clothes they wear, the rules they follow, and their values give particular places unique character and atmosphere. Some of these places in NYC, for instance, become known as neighborhoods such as Chinatown.

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In cultural psychology, Cole (1996) points out that context is not simply something which "surrounds" and, hence, shapes the cultural tools we use (e.g., the language we might use or clothing we might wear at a particular time and place), but rather, context is "that which surrounds *and* that which weaves together" (p. 143; emphasis not in original). Artifacts, therefore, *are* contextual, at once invested with meaning in local places *and* constitute and produce local places themselves. Taking clothing as an example, in Eglinton's (2013) ethnography of youth culture in two communities (New York City and subarctic Canada), the black and Latino young people she worked with in New York City described a "New York style" as baggy pants, puffy coats, sneakers, or big work boots, and girls in tight jeans. This "New York style" is a style born of hip-hop culture, which is connected to urban life, and represents "urban storms to be weathered" (Rose 1994, p. 38). As NYC youth wore their puffy coats and tight jeans, they produced and embodied a particular landscape (or style) of New York. Indeed, the distinctly *urban* style was also produced by youth in rural subarctic Canada but with different implications. The girls in subarctic Canada spoke about the various social difficulties encountered when wearing the tight jeans that the girls in New York described as "New York style." They would be asked why they were "dressing city." Specifically, these girls were challenged by people in their community who wanted to know why they were wearing a style that was not reflected in and constituted by local morays. By wearing "New York style" in a rural, subarctic community, young people created a contrast between the relaxed utility-oriented atmosphere that constituted their particular rural community and themselves.

Young people's individual and collective lives, experiences, histories, and identities are implicated in the relationship between culture and place. People, in this case young people, construct their identities through cultural practices using multiple available cultural artifacts such as local values, language, and popular culture. As young people use and give meaning to cultural artifacts through human (inter)action, they are "internalized" (Vygotsky 1978) – at once (re)constructing and (re)producing aspects of self and worlds (Castells 2004, p. 7). In this proposed co-constitutive framework, identities develop in concert with the social and cultural worlds that make up local places. Young people change, impact, and transform both themselves and the world around them as they use cultural artifacts and engage in mediated action (see Eglinton 2013 for further elaboration on a relational framework for understanding youth identities).

An Example of Youth Well-Being in an Alaska Native Context

An example from an Alaska Native research project illustrates how the use of this relational perspective can contribute to an understanding of youth well-being. The example examines most pointedly the power of context in shaping youth opportunities and points to the co-constitutive aspects of Alaska Native youth well-being. The research project analyzed digital stories produced by Inupiat young people in a rural region of Alaska. Digital stories are three- to five-minute visual narratives that synthesize images, video, audio recordings of voice, background music, and text to create personal stories (Gubrium and Turner 2011; Lambert 2006). Young people's digital stories are cultural artifacts that offer opportunities to explore their lives, inhabited spaces, cultural resources, and the ways in which they are negotiating their identities in a social landscape increasingly different from that of their parents and grandparents (Wexler 2013; Wexler et al. 2012). The digital stories themselves provide clues to better understand youth self-perceptions, their ideas of success, and – particularly focusing on those stories that underscored ideals, daily lives, and optimism – their representations of lived well-being. Digital stories, then, are places to rework ethnic pride and cultural identities that link to global youth culture and to traditional Inupiat ideas of

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masculinity and mastery. The methods employed in the research are described elsewhere (Wexler et al. 2012). Most relevant to this chapter is the analysis which focused on the young people's depictions of their successes, self-representations, and important relationships.

Young Inupiat people's digital stories illustrate forms of gender expression, ideas about achievement, and access to different forms of participation and cultural mores. For both boys and girls, sites of success or achievement were often linked to participation in particular activities. These activities were "naturalized" and most available to *either* girls or boys. Boys' successes focused largely on those spaces considered masculine, such as sports and riding fast machines (snow-gos, all-terrain vehicles, motor boats), whereas girls tended to depict achievement through participation in what are primarily considered feminine activities, such as participating in family life and taking care of children. For girls, the segments often highlighted more traditional adult roles, such as homemaking or supporting others' success. For boys, sites of achievement centered more firmly on hunting and fishing activities. Notably, sites of achievement were more varied and readily available to girls, when compared to those depicted in boys' stories.

It is important to consider how young people's depictions of their "sites of achievement" reflect social expectations, opportunities, and even economic disparities that create different kinds of access to cultural resources. Specifically, understanding how young people are formulating their identities, conceptualizing their successes, building their relationships, and imagining their future is constrained and expanded by the local and the geopolitical. It is relational. In the digital storytelling project, the kinds of successes depicted by boys in their stories were more limited in scope and availability than those for girls. The activities in which young women engaged, such as child-rearing, babysitting, and school success, are not only deemed necessary and "natural" activities for young women in everyday life, they are also closely aligned with traditional Inupiat values and with culturally salient gender roles. In other words, not only are these gendered accomplishments highly accessible to girls, they are also valued by dominant society and by the girls' local community. In this way, girls appear to have multiple acceptable, recognized, and valued sites of achievement available. These achievements included participating in youth culture (i.e., hanging out with friends, surfing the Internet, achieving in school) and activities that reflected traditional culture (i.e., taking care of children, caring for elders).

In contrast, boys had few "natural" and/or "necessary" culturally salient gender roles for them to play in the community. Cultural artifacts, such as gender roles, mediate boys' understanding of what it means to be a successful male. Boys' digital stories did not feature many opportunities that were at once valued culturally and by dominant society. Instead, their stories tended to embrace artifacts and cultural markers from marginalized groups (i.e., hip-hop, gangster poses) but deployed them in ways that reflected Inupiat cultural values. For instance, many of the boys' digital stories had images of groups of same sex peers in baggy "New York style" pants, posing with their hands making "gang signs" in front of a particularly good fish catch. Very few boys highlighted academic or professional success. Instead – as the example above illustrates – boys' sites of achievement depicted hunting, fishing, the ability to drive fast and skillfully (by snow machine, boat, four-wheeler, and automobile), and sports. Yet, although these are all culturally valued skills, expensive gas prices and equipment costs often preclude these activities. Therefore, not all boys have access to these sites of achievement. While boys certainly depicted images of successful friendship groups and belonging, it could be that their limited opportunities for participation in culturally valued (expensive) activities mean that there are fewer valued spaces for them to enjoy success.

As this example suggests, considering the accomplishments, events, and activities featured in the young people's digital stories as valid and important, "artifacts" can provide insight into how young people in one community represent, produce, and negotiate their contexts, values, and selves. The

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scope and variability of young people's "sites of achievement" provide insight into the ways that context – including gender and economic factors – can narrow (or expand) young people's understanding of self and access to well-being. In this example, boys depict successes that focus more on factors relegated to "hobbies," such as sports, riding things well, hunting, and fishing. While highly valued forms of achievement in Inupiat society, not all of these achievements are necessarily valued in dominant society. In addition, even those activities that are valued locally are not always accessible due to monetary constraints. On the other hand, girls' sites of achievement include more practical skills and academics (i.e., childcare and graduation) and activities that are naturalized through gender expectations but are also necessary and perhaps easier to achieve given the opportunities available to them.

The digital storytelling project fits within our co-constitutive framework of well-being for a number of reasons. First, the project focused on youth-produced digital stories as cultural artifacts that are pregnant with significance on multiple levels. Youth digital stories provide insight to understand young people's individual and collective lives, experiences, histories, and identities. The local values, language, and popular culture references in these cultural artifacts help us understand the ways in which young Inupiat are shaped by, for instance, gendered constructions of achievement. Our exploration asks not only how young people construct their identities through cultural artifacts and interactions but also how these constructions may be "internalized" (Vygotsky 1978).

Since our framework emphasizes the co-constitutive elements of youth well-being, it is important to consider how identities can develop in concert with the social and cultural worlds that make up local places. For boys, opportunities for (re)constructing and (re)producing aspects of self and worlds are constrained by narrow gendered notions of success and by the economic resources required to access many male sites of achievement. It follows, then, that youth health disparities are greatest among indigenous males (Wexler et al. 2012). In contrast, young Inupiat women are reshaping their worlds through expanded opportunities for leadership and livelihood. Although traditionally a male-dominated society (Burch 2006), women are currently more likely to be the primary breadwinner of Inupiat families and are progressively leading more tribal organizations and government entities. Through this example, it is clear that youth well-being is a fluid and co-constituted state in which young people change, impact, and transform both themselves and the world as they use cultural artifacts and engage in mediated action (Eglinton 2013).

Conclusion and Future Directions

This chapter opens up thinking about youth well-being as a relational process which is both constrained and enabled by context or "place" including physical and social geographies. This perspective highlights some of the more static, linear, and narrow frameworks for conceptualizing youth well-being and, drawing on sociocultural theories and perspectives from human geography, began to offer a potential theoretical framework featuring a more inclusive and dynamic understanding. Specifically, a framework that takes into account the power of context in well-being in addition to the role youths themselves play in shaping and understanding their own identities and worlds. Illustrating aspects of this relational conceptualization of youth well-being, we discuss an example from the lives of indigenous young people in Northwest Alaska. The relational example illustrates the significance of context in shaping youth experiences, opportunities and possibilities, and access to well-being. The insights provided through a relational lens help to pinpoint interactive mechanisms of resilience and well-being. With this perspective, young people work within the

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constraints of their sociocultural, economic, and political environments to reshape the contours of their local landscapes. The interactive, relational perspective, then, pushes the World Health Organization (2011) definition of well-being from one which focuses on coping strategies, productivity, and the ability to contribute to one's community to a conception of co-constituted well-being that manifests in one's ability to create their own potential through the remaking of their worlds.

Cross-References

▶ 'Black Neighbourhoods' and 'Race', Placed Identities in Youth Transition to Adulthoods
▶ Time and Space in Youth Studies
▶ Youth, Relationality, and Space: Conceptual Resources for Youth Studies from Critical Human Geography

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